

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Honeybees communicate the location of food sources through a behavior known as the waggle dance. A forager bee returning to the hive performs a figure-eight pattern, with the angle of the central 'waggle' run indicating the direction relative to the sun and the duration of the run corresponding to the distance. Other bees observe the dance and then fly directly to the food source. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To highlight the role of the sun's position in guiding honeybee foraging behavior
- B: To describe how honeybees use a specific behavior to share information about food locations
- C: To illustrate the broader significance of figure-eight patterns in animal communication
- D: To detail how individual forager bees locate and assess food sources before returning to the hive

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: ask what the ENTIRE passage is about, not just one sentence. The sun (A) and the figure-eight (C) are supporting details of the mechanism, not the main point. D confuses communicating a location with finding it -- the passage is about telling other bees where food is, not about how the forager found it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The following text is from Clara Mwangi's 2020 short story collection *Sundown Roads*. The old fisherman sat at the end of the dock, mending his net with fingers that had not lost their swiftness despite the years. His grandson watched, trying to mimic the knots, but the boy's loops came undone as quickly as he tied them. 'Patience,' the old man said, without looking up. 'The net does not care how fast you work. It cares that you finish.' Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To depict the difficulty of acquiring a traditional craft without formal instruction
- B: To establish a contrast between the old man's composure and the boy's frustration in order to characterize both figures
- C: To suggest that net-mending is a disappearing skill that younger generations are struggling to preserve
- D: To portray a moment in which an elder passes on a lesson about patience through a shared task

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: the old man's direct speech ('Patience...') signals the scene's function -- delivering a lesson. A focuses on difficulty, which is present but secondary. B notes a real detail (contrast), but contrast is the setup, not the purpose. C infers a cultural-loss theme the passage never raises.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: A public library in Portland, Oregon, recently eliminated overdue fines for all borrowers. Library officials reported that within six months, the number of active cardholders increased by 15 percent, and the rate at which overdue materials were returned actually rose. The program's supporters argue that fines disproportionately discourage low-income residents from using library services. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To present the outcomes and reasoning behind a library's decision to eliminate overdue fines
- B: To demonstrate that low-income residents are the primary beneficiaries of fine-free library policies
- C: To recommend that all public libraries nationwide adopt fine-free borrowing policies
- D: To provide evidence that financial penalties are generally ineffective at encouraging the return of borrowed materials

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: check whether the passage reports or recommends. It reports one library's results and supporters' rationale -- it does not tell other libraries what to do (C). B narrows to one detail (low-income impact). D overgeneralizes: the passage shows one library's results, not a broad claim about fines everywhere.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The Silk Road was not a single road but a network of trade routes connecting East Asia with the Mediterranean. Merchants transported goods such as silk, spices, and precious metals across thousands of miles, but the routes also facilitated the exchange of ideas, religions, and technologies between civilizations that might otherwise have had little contact. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To identify the specific goods that were most frequently transported along the Silk Road's trade routes

B: To argue that the cultural exchanges enabled by the Silk Road were more consequential than its commercial function

C: To describe the Silk Road as a network that enabled both commercial trade and cultural exchange across distant regions

D: To explain why the Silk Road consisted of multiple routes rather than a single continuous road

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: when a passage covers TWO things (trade AND ideas), the correct answer must capture both. A only covers goods. B ranks one over the other, but the passage uses 'also,' not 'more importantly.' D focuses on the first sentence's clarification, which is a minor structural detail.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Venus flytraps capture insects using hinged leaves that snap shut when trigger hairs on their inner surfaces are touched. The plant requires two stimulations of the trigger hairs within approximately twenty seconds to close, a mechanism that prevents the trap from wasting energy on false alarms such as falling raindrops. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To classify the Venus flytrap as a uniquely efficient species among carnivorous plants

B: To describe the Venus flytrap's trapping mechanism and explain the function of its two-touch requirement

C: To explain the biological process by which the Venus flytrap's hinged leaves detect and respond to physical contact

D: To argue that the Venus flytrap's energy-conservation strategy is more advanced than those of other carnivorous plants

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: the passage does two things -- describes HOW the trap works AND explains WHY it needs two touches. C only covers the 'how' (detection/response), missing the energy-saving purpose. A and D both introduce comparisons to other species that the passage never makes.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The following text is from Daniel Okwu's 2019 novel *Bridge of Reeds*. When the floodwaters rose, the village council debated whether to reinforce the old levee or abandon it and retreat to higher ground. Elder Nkechi listened to both sides and then reminded the council that the same debate had occurred forty years earlier, and that the levee builders had won then too. 'We chose the levee,' she said, 'and we have been repairing it ever since.' Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To illustrate a community's resilience in repeatedly overcoming the challenges posed by flooding

B: To present the arguments both for and against levee construction so that the reader can evaluate each position

C: To describe the engineering difficulties involved in maintaining a levee over several decades

D: To present a character's observation that a past decision has committed the village to an ongoing burden

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: read tone carefully. 'We have been repairing it ever since' is ironic, not celebratory. A misreads the tone as positive ('resilience'), but Nkechi frames the levee choice as a burden. B says both sides are presented for the reader to judge, but the text highlights Nkechi's pointed observation. C invents engineering details the passage never provides.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Economist Rita Vasquez found that small businesses in walkable neighborhoods generate more revenue per square foot than comparable businesses on car-dependent commercial strips. Vasquez attributes this difference to higher pedestrian traffic, which increases the likelihood of impulse visits to shops and restaurants. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To present a researcher's finding linking walkability to higher small-business revenue and to identify a proposed cause for that relationship

B: To argue that urban planning policies should prioritize walkability over vehicle access in commercial areas

C: To compare the revenue performance of small businesses with that of large retail chains in walkable areas

D: To describe the methods Vasquez used to measure the effect of pedestrian traffic on business revenue

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: research passages that present a finding and a proposed cause are reporting, not recommending. B converts a finding into a policy argument the passage never makes. C introduces large retail chains, which are never mentioned. D focuses on methods, which are not discussed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Migratory birds navigate using a variety of cues, including the position of the sun, the pattern of stars, and Earth's magnetic field. Ornithologist Hana Petrov recently demonstrated that European robins possess a protein called cryptochrome in their retinas that is sensitive to magnetic fields. Petrov's experiments showed that when cryptochrome function was disrupted chemically, the birds' ability to orient toward magnetic north declined significantly, though their use of solar and stellar cues remained unaffected. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To compare the relative importance of solar, stellar, and magnetic cues in the navigation of migratory birds

B: To demonstrate that disrupting cryptochrome eliminates all navigational ability in European robins

C: To introduce a researcher's evidence that a specific protein is involved in magnetic navigation in one bird species

D: To explain why European robins depend on magnetic fields more heavily than other migratory species do

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: match the passage's specificity. The passage is about ONE protein in ONE species -- not a ranking of cues (A), not total navigational loss (B -- solar/stellar cues were unaffected), and not a comparison across species (D).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Though Harriet Jacobs's 1861 autobiography is now regarded as a landmark of American literature, it was largely overlooked for more than a century after its publication. Literary scholar Jean Fagan Yellin spent years verifying the text's authenticity and tracing its historical references, publishing a critical edition in 1987 that restored the work to scholarly attention. Yellin's efforts revealed the complexity of Jacobs's narrative strategies and established the autobiography as essential reading in courses on American history and literature. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To examine the narrative strategies that made Jacobs's autobiography a difficult text for nineteenth-century readers to accept

B: To describe how a scholar's research brought a neglected autobiography to prominence and demonstrated its literary significance

C: To argue that literary scholars before Yellin deliberately ignored Jacobs's autobiography because of their own biases

D: To trace the full publication history of Jacobs's autobiography from its initial release through multiple critical editions

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: identify WHO the passage is really about. The subject is Yellin's effort, not Jacobs's writing techniques (A). C uses 'deliberately ignored,' but the passage says 'largely overlooked' -- a big difference in intent. D implies a detailed timeline of editions, but the passage names only two moments (1861 and 1987).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: When a forest fire burns through an ecosystem, it clears dead vegetation and returns nutrients to the soil, creating conditions favorable for new growth. Ecologist David Moreno has found, however, that the increasing frequency of fires in some Mediterranean regions is shortening the recovery interval to the point where soil nutrients are depleted faster than they can be replenished. Moreno warns that without longer intervals between fires, some ecosystems may shift permanently from forest to shrubland. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To describe the chemical processes by which fire converts dead vegetation into soil nutrients

B: To argue that all fires in Mediterranean forests should be actively suppressed to prevent ecological damage

C: To present evidence that forest fires are always beneficial when they occur at naturally determined intervals

D: To explain that while fire can benefit ecosystems, excessively frequent fires risk causing irreversible ecological change

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: 'however' signals a qualification. The passage says fire helps AND that too-frequent fire hurts. Any answer that drops half of this two-part structure is wrong. A covers only the benefit side. B converts a warning into a call for total suppression. C uses 'always beneficial,' but the passage's whole point is that frequency matters.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Yuki Tanabe's 2022 poetry collection *Tidal Ledger*. She measured the days not by clocks but by the slow accumulation of shells along the windowsill -- each one a journey completed by the tide and left behind. By August the sill was full, and she had to decide whether to make room for more or to accept that the collection was finished. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To use the image of accumulating shells as a reflection on the passage of time and the limits of what can be held onto

B: To describe the speaker's daily habit of gathering natural objects from the shoreline

C: To illustrate the speaker's growing frustration with the physical constraints of her living space

D: To convey the speaker's appreciation for the predictable rhythms of the ocean across a single season

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: in poetry, look for figurative meaning first. 'Measured the days...by shells' signals metaphor -- shells stand for time. B and C read the passage literally (collecting things, running out of space). D captures a surface detail (ocean rhythms) but misses the deeper point about time and the decision to stop accumulating.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Political scientist Amara Diallo examined voter turnout in local elections across twelve democracies and found that countries with compulsory voting laws had turnout rates averaging 89 percent, compared with 55 percent in countries without such laws. Diallo notes, however, that high turnout alone does not ensure representative outcomes; in some compulsory-voting countries, a significant share of ballots are cast blank or deliberately spoiled, suggesting that mandatory participation may not translate into engaged civic behavior. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To argue that compulsory voting is the most effective method for ensuring that election outcomes reflect the will of the electorate

B: To present data showing compulsory voting increases turnout while noting that higher turnout may not reflect deeper civic engagement

C: To demonstrate that blank and spoiled ballots in compulsory-voting countries undermine the legitimacy of those countries' elections

D: To compare the quality of democratic representation in compulsory-voting and voluntary-voting systems

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: when a passage presents data and then qualifies it with 'however,' the correct answer must capture BOTH parts. A drops the qualification entirely. C overstates (spoiled ballots are noted as a pattern, not framed as undermining legitimacy). D says the passage compares quality of representation, but it only raises a concern, not a full comparison.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: During the construction of the Panama Canal in the early 1900s, tropical diseases -- particularly malaria and yellow fever -- killed thousands of workers and threatened to halt the project. Chief sanitary officer William Gorgas implemented an aggressive mosquito-control campaign, draining standing water and fumigating buildings across the Canal Zone. The campaign dramatically reduced disease-related deaths and allowed construction to proceed, demonstrating the practical impact of public-health measures on large-scale engineering projects. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To criticize the working conditions that endangered laborers during the construction of the Panama Canal

B: To describe the specific mosquito-control methods that William Gorgas introduced in tropical regions worldwide

C: To illustrate how a targeted public-health campaign proved essential to the completion of a major engineering project

D: To argue that Gorgas's sanitation techniques were more effective than the medical treatments available during the same period

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: check the passage's final clause -- 'demonstrating the practical impact of public-health measures on large-scale engineering projects.' That tells you the purpose directly. A misreads the tone (no criticism of conditions). B says 'worldwide,' but the passage is about the Canal Zone only. D introduces a comparison to medical treatments that is never discussed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Most animals that live at extreme ocean depths are small, but the giant isopod can reach lengths of over forty centimeters. Marine biologist Elena Rossi hypothesizes that deep-sea gigantism in isopods results from a combination of low predation pressure, cold temperatures that slow metabolism, and the adaptive advantage of a larger body for storing energy during long intervals between meals. Rossi acknowledges, however, that these factors alone may not fully explain the phenomenon, since other deep-sea crustaceans exposed to similar conditions remain small. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To argue that low predation pressure is the single most important cause of deep-sea gigantism across all crustacean species

B: To describe the environmental conditions that make extreme ocean depths inhospitable for large organisms

C: To explain why deep-sea organisms generally tend to be smaller than their shallow-water counterparts

D: To present a hypothesis about why giant isopods grow unusually large while acknowledging that the hypothesis may be incomplete

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: 'hypothesizes' plus 'acknowledges, however' signals a tentative claim with a caveat. The correct answer must include both. A singles out one factor and drops the caveat. B shifts focus to environmental conditions in general. C reverses the premise -- the passage asks why one species is BIG, not why others are small.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Omar Bello's 2015 novel *The Quiet Republic*. Augusto had always believed that silence was a form of consent, but after years of living in the capital he began to suspect it was something else entirely -- a form of endurance. The people around him did not speak because they had nothing to say; they did not speak because the cost of speaking was too high, and silence was the only currency they could afford to spend. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To convey a character's evolving understanding of silence as a survival strategy shaped by an oppressive environment

B: To describe the economic pressures that make daily life in the capital difficult for ordinary citizens

C: To argue that silence should be understood as a morally defensible alternative to open protest against injustice

D: To contrast Augusto's personal views on silence with the opposing views held by more outspoken characters in the novel

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: 'had always believed...but began to suspect' signals a CHANGE in the character's thinking. B reads 'currency' literally as economics, missing the metaphor. C converts one character's realization into a moral argument the text does not make. D introduces 'outspoken characters' who never appear in the passage.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Anthropologist Keiko Yamamoto studied gift-exchange practices in three Pacific Island communities and found that the social status of the giver, rather than the monetary value of the gift, determined how recipients perceived the exchange. Gifts from community leaders were treated with greater reverence regardless of their material worth, while identical items from lower-status individuals received more modest acknowledgment. Yamamoto argues that these practices reveal how social hierarchies are reinforced through everyday rituals. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To argue that social hierarchies in Pacific Island communities are maintained primarily through the unequal distribution of material wealth

B: To present research showing that the social meaning of gift exchange is shaped more by the giver's status than by the gift's material value

C: To describe the types of gifts most commonly exchanged among community leaders in three Pacific Island cultures

D: To demonstrate that gift-exchange rituals in Pacific Island communities serve a fundamentally different social function than similar rituals in Western cultures

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: identify the key variable. The passage says STATUS, not monetary value, drives perception. A reverses this by saying hierarchies come from 'unequal distribution of material wealth.' C focuses on cataloging gift types, which the passage does not do. D introduces a comparison to Western cultures that is never made.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The Mpemba effect -- the observation that, under certain conditions, hot water can freeze faster than cold water -- has puzzled scientists for decades. Physicist Lena Borg recently proposed that the effect arises because heating alters the hydrogen-bond network in water, creating a molecular configuration that releases energy more rapidly during cooling. Borg's simulations support this mechanism, but experimental confirmation has proven difficult because the effect is sensitive to variables such as container shape and ambient humidity. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To argue that the Mpemba effect has been conclusively resolved by Borg's computational simulations

B: To compare multiple competing hypotheses about why hot water can sometimes freeze faster than cold water

C: To describe the practical difficulties researchers face when designing controlled experiments involving water's freezing point

D: To introduce a proposed mechanism for a long-standing scientific puzzle while noting that experimental verification remains elusive

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: watch the status-of-evidence language. 'Proposed,' 'simulations support,' and 'experimental confirmation has proven difficult' all signal that the mechanism is not yet confirmed. A says 'conclusively resolved,' which contradicts the passage. B says 'multiple competing hypotheses,' but only one is discussed. C focuses on experimental challenges, which are a secondary point.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Conventional models of stellar evolution predict that stars below a certain mass threshold will end their lives as white dwarfs without undergoing a supernova explosion. Astrophysicist Ravi Chandrasekaran has identified a class of anomalous transient events in which low-mass stars appear to produce brief, luminous flares that share some spectroscopic signatures with supernovae but lack others, such as the characteristic emission lines of heavy elements. Chandrasekaran suggests these events may represent a previously unrecognized end-of-life pathway for certain low-mass stars, though he concedes that instrumental artifacts have not been conclusively ruled out. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To explain the spectroscopic methods astrophysicists use to classify different types of supernova events
- B: To argue that the conventional model of stellar evolution is no longer able to account for the observed behavior of low-mass stars
- C: To describe newly observed stellar events that may challenge existing models while acknowledging that the observations carry unresolved uncertainties
- D: To compare the end-of-life processes of low-mass stars with those of high-mass stars in order to refine current classification systems

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: 'suggests,' 'may represent,' and 'concedes that...not conclusively ruled out' are hedging language. The passage presents a tentative challenge, not a definitive refutation. B drops all hedging ('no longer able to account'). A misidentifies the focus as methods. D introduces high-mass stars, which are never discussed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Historian Fatima Al-Rashid has re-evaluated the role of medieval Islamic hospitals, known as bimaristans, in the development of clinical medicine. While earlier Western scholarship often treated bimaristans as charitable institutions with minimal medical rigor, Al-Rashid's archival research reveals detailed patient records, systematic drug trials, and specialized wards organized by disease type -- practices that preceded comparable European developments by several centuries. Al-Rashid does not claim that bimaristans were modern hospitals in disguise; rather, she argues that their contributions to evidence-based practice deserve fuller recognition in histories of medicine. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To present a historian's argument that medieval Islamic hospitals were more medically sophisticated than earlier Western scholarship acknowledged

B: To argue that bimaristans functioned in ways identical to those of modern evidence-based medical institutions

C: To criticize Western historians for deliberately omitting bimaristans from histories of clinical medicine

D: To describe the archival methods Al-Rashid used to reconstruct the internal organization of medieval Islamic hospitals

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: the passage explicitly says Al-Rashid 'does not claim that bimaristans were modern hospitals in disguise,' which rules out B immediately. C says 'deliberately omitting,' but the passage only says earlier scholarship 'treated' them as less rigorous -- no malice is attributed. D focuses on methods, which are not described in detail.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Neuroscientist Tomoko Ishikawa has questioned whether the widely cited 'left brain / right brain' framework -- which holds that analytical thinking is localized in the left hemisphere and creative thinking in the right -- accurately reflects neural processing. Ishikawa's functional MRI studies show that both creative and analytical tasks activate distributed networks spanning both hemispheres, with the degree of lateralization varying substantially among individuals. She argues that while some neural functions are lateralized (e.g., language production), the popular dichotomy oversimplifies brain organization and may lead educators to design curricula around a misleading model. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To argue that functional MRI technology has proven more reliable than earlier methods for studying the lateralization of brain functions
- B: To present a researcher's evidence that the popular left-brain/right-brain framework oversimplifies how the brain processes information
- C: To explain why the degree of hemispheric lateralization varies more among individuals than neuroscientists previously expected
- D: To compare Ishikawa's distributed-network model of the brain with the conventional hemispheric-specialization framework

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: identify the core claim. Ishikawa's point is that the popular dichotomy 'oversimplifies brain organization.' A shifts focus to fMRI technology, which is a tool, not the argument. C picks up a detail (individual variation) but misses the main point about the framework being oversimplified. D frames Ishikawa as offering a competing 'model,' but she is critiquing the existing one, not proposing a replacement.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 21

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The following text is from Saoirse Brennan's 2018 essay collection *Borrowed Light*. I had expected grief to arrive all at once, like a wave, but instead it came in installments -- a song on the radio, a handwriting sample on a grocery list, the particular way afternoon light fell across a chair no one sat in anymore. Each installment was small enough to survive, which was, I think, the only reason I survived them all. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To analyze the psychological stages through which a person typically processes the experience of loss

B: To argue that grief experienced gradually in small moments is ultimately easier to endure than grief that arrives suddenly

C: To suggest that everyday sensory details such as songs and light can unexpectedly trigger intense emotional responses

D: To describe the speaker's experience of grief as arriving gradually through ordinary moments rather than as a single overwhelming event

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: personal essays describe experience; they do not typically construct clinical analyses or formal arguments. A imposes a clinical framework ('psychological stages') that the passage does not use. B converts a personal observation into a comparative argument ('easier to endure'). C captures the trigger detail but misses the central contrast between expected wave and actual installments.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 22

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The standard model of superconductivity, proposed by Bardeen, Cooper, and Schrieffer, explains the phenomenon through the formation of electron pairs at very low temperatures. However, certain copper-oxide compounds become superconducting at temperatures far above those predicted by the standard model. Physicist Amina Kessler has proposed that in these materials, magnetic fluctuations rather than lattice vibrations mediate electron pairing. Kessler's model successfully predicts the transition temperatures of several known high-temperature superconductors, but it has yet to account for anomalies observed in newly synthesized nickel-oxide compounds. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To argue that the Bardeen-Cooper-Schrieffer model of superconductivity is fundamentally flawed and must be replaced entirely

B: To describe the differences between copper-oxide and nickel-oxide compounds in their capacity to act as superconductors

C: To introduce an alternative model that addresses a limitation of the standard theory while noting that the new model has its own unresolved challenges

D: To explain the physical conditions under which certain materials become superconducting at unexpectedly high temperatures

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: the passage follows a pattern: standard model has a gap --> new model fills it --> new model has its own gap. The correct answer must capture this three-part structure. A says 'fundamentally flawed' and 'replaced entirely,' which is too strong. B focuses on a material comparison that is incidental. D is too vague and omits both models.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 23

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Archaeological evidence from the site of Mohenjo-daro in present-day Pakistan reveals a remarkably uniform urban plan: streets arranged in a grid, standardized brick sizes across structures, and an elaborate drainage system. Archaeologist Prerna Malhotra argues that this uniformity implies a centralized planning authority, but she cautions against equating centralization with autocracy. Malhotra points out that the absence of palatial structures and monumental royal tombs at Mohenjo-daro suggests a governance model quite different from the hierarchical kingships of contemporary Mesopotamian cities. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To present an archaeologist's argument that Mohenjo-daro's urban uniformity suggests centralized planning while distinguishing that authority from autocratic rule

B: To argue that the absence of palatial structures at Mohenjo-daro proves the city was governed through a democratic system

C: To compare the governance structures of Mohenjo-daro and contemporary Mesopotamian cities in order to determine which was more effective

D: To describe the standardized architectural features of Mohenjo-daro as evidence of the city's advanced engineering capabilities

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: Malhotra makes a two-part argument: uniformity implies centralization, BUT centralization does not mean autocracy. The correct answer must capture the distinction. B jumps to 'democratic,' a term the passage never uses. C says the comparison is about effectiveness, but Malhotra uses Mesopotamia only to highlight a contrast, not to rank systems. D focuses on engineering, missing the governance argument entirely.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 24

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Philosopher Kwame Asante has critiqued the notion of 'meritocracy' by arguing that what societies label as individual merit is often inseparable from structural advantages such as access to quality education, professional networks, and inherited wealth. Asante does not deny that talent and effort matter; rather, he contends that treating outcomes as purely merit-based obscures the role of systemic factors and can be used to justify existing inequalities as natural and deserved. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To argue that individual talent and effort have no meaningful influence on a person's outcomes in modern societies

B: To trace the historical evolution of the concept of meritocracy across different political traditions

C: To compare Asante's critique of meritocracy with the views of philosophers who defend the concept as valid

D: To present a philosopher's argument that treating outcomes as purely merit-based obscures structural factors and can legitimize inequality

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: when a passage says 'does not deny X; rather, argues Y,' the correct answer must reflect Y without contradicting X. A directly contradicts the passage by saying talent has 'no meaningful influence.' B introduces a historical overview the passage never provides. C introduces defenders of meritocracy who are never discussed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 25

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The following text is from Nikolai Avenov's 2021 novel *The Understory*. The botanist cataloged each species with the same meticulous care, whether it was a towering mahogany or a moss no larger than a thumbprint. His colleagues teased him for the hours he spent on organisms that would never appear in a textbook, but he maintained that significance was not the same as visibility. The forest, he believed, was held together not by its tallest trees but by the unseen threads connecting root to fungus to soil. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To describe the daily research methods of a field botanist cataloging species in a tropical forest ecosystem
- B: To criticize the broader scientific community for prioritizing well-known species over those that receive less scholarly attention
- C: To convey a character's belief that the least conspicuous organisms in an ecosystem are often the most ecologically important
- D: To illustrate the professional tension between a meticulous researcher and colleagues who value efficiency over thoroughness

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Shortcut: look for the character's stated belief. 'Significance was not the same as visibility' and 'held together...by the unseen threads' express a philosophy about hidden importance. A reduces the passage to routine description, missing the philosophy. B turns the colleagues' teasing into the text's own critique of science. D introduces 'efficiency' as the colleagues' value, but the passage says they teased him about textbook relevance, not efficiency.

END QUESTION